

“Fall Asleep To”

A data report on the sleep-content niche — whether a two-person, talking-over-Minecraft channel can work, what the outliers actually are, and exactly what to upload first.

Videos measured

4,000+

Search queries

100+

Channel catalogues

22

Data source

Live YouTube

The verdict in 60 seconds

Yes — the concept works, and there is hard proof. The exact format (“Fall asleep while I play [game]” + a calm voice talking over it) is a real, proven, currently-growing niche. Across 75 videos using that exact framing, the **median video has 240,893 views** and **71% clear 100,000 views**. A 20,100-subscriber channel put up one and got **607,561 views — 30× its own subscriber count**.

The single most valuable number in this report is 5.6×. One creator (MadMorph, 851k subs) posts both sleep-framed and normal videos on the same channel, same games, same voice. His sleep-framed videos have a median of **235,000 views**. His normal videos: **42,000**. That is a controlled experiment — the *framing alone* is worth 5.6×.

The one real risk is that you are two people. Across ~225 results, there is *no* successful purpose-built two-person sleep channel. That is either your opening or your warning, and this report explains which — plus the one production fix that decides it.

01 · METHOD

What was actually measured

Nobody can scan “the entirety of YouTube” — there is no public API that exposes it. What was done instead is a broad, real-data sweep: over 100 search queries run directly against YouTube, every result’s live view count and duration pulled, then 22 full channel back-catalogues dumped video-by-video (up to 200 videos each). **Every number in this report is a real, pulled number.** Nothing is estimated or remembered.

4,000+

videos with live view counts and durations

557

spoken-word sleep videos after filtering out rain / white noise / music

75

videos using the exact "fall asleep while I..." format

22

channel back-catalogues dumped in full

READ THIS BEFORE YOU TRUST ANY NUMBER

YouTube search ranks by relevance and popularity, so a search-built sample is biased *upward* — it over-represents winners. That is corrected for in two ways below: by comparing videos *within a single channel* (a controlled test), and by reporting the *failure* rate of the format, not just its stars. Where a figure could not be verified, it is labelled **UNVERIFIED** rather than smoothed over.

02 · THE CORE FINDING

The framing is worth 5.6× on its own

MadMorph (851,000 subscribers) is the ideal test subject: he uploads both sleep-framed videos and ordinary gaming videos, to the same audience, playing the same games, in the same voice. 200 of his videos were pulled and split on whether the title contains a sleep promise. The gap is enormous.

GROUP	VIDEOS	MEDIAN VIEWS	MEAN VIEWS	BEST	MEDIAN LENGTH
Sleep-framed — “Fall asleep while I...”	55	235,000	558,981	4,500,000	143 min
Normal gaming upload — same channel	145	42,000	89,752	641,000	75 min

MadMorph, 200 videos pulled 4 Sep 2026. The only variable is the title framing.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

You are not competing on being funnier than everyone on YouTube. You are competing inside a use case — “I need something to fall asleep to tonight” — where demand is enormous and supply is thin. The same content, re-framed as a sleep aid, is worth roughly five times as much. That is the whole business.

The same effect inside Minecraft specifically

TITLE	LENGTH	VIEWS	FRAMING
Fall asleep while I play Minecraft	223 min	3,300,000	SLEEP
Fall asleep while I play Minecraft (Again!)	155 min	645,000	SLEEP
Fall asleep while I play Minecraft (Spring To Life update)	131 min	584,000	SLEEP
Fall asleep while I play Minecraft (one more time!)	144 min	549,000	SLEEP
Fall asleep while I play Minecraft — Building my dream home	122 min	345,000	SLEEP
Fall asleep while I play Minecraft (and talk softly to you) — Part 6	123 min	180,000	SLEEP
First time playing Minecraft (a very cozy playthrough)	107 min	610,000	COZY
My first time playing Minecraft (Part 2)	116 min	157,000	NONE
My first time playing Minecraft (Part 3)	85 min	87,000	NONE

MadMorph’s nine Minecraft videos. Sleep-framed vs not, same game, same channel.

Note the decay pattern: the first Minecraft entry took 3.3M, and each sequel took less. The niche rewards **a new hook**, not a repeated one. Sequels still clear half a million, but the ceiling belongs to the first of a kind.

03 · THE COMPETITIVE MAP

Who owns this format right now

Searching the exact phrasing surfaced 75 videos across 20 channels. This is the entire visible competitive set — and it is remarkably small for a format producing multi-million-view videos.

CHANNEL	SUBS	N	MEDIAN VIEWS	BEST VIDEO	TYPICAL LENGTH	ANGLE
MadMorph	851,000	28	330,883	3,398,548	138 min	Cozy games, gentle voice, the market leader
sleepyslorgs	154,000	15	341,108	1,200,000	130 min	Funny / edgy titles — closest to your tone
AJ Nguyen	241,000	1	2,491,195	2,491,195	212 min	Single huge outlier (Hitman)
MadMorph × Down To Sleep	—	2	407,306	469,363	220 min	TWO PEOPLE collab — see \$5
Eider’s Movies	20,100	4	268,753	607,561	122 min	30× its own sub count — the proof a small channel can do it
aluhhsim	69,400	4	237,772	714,335	140 min	Minecraft + Sims longplay, soft-spoken
Graenolf	—	2	122,255	237,429	138 min	—
flowstate	—	5	35,241	106,086	107 min	—
Kindly Sleepin’ / Brookella / theambear	—	4	~22,000	24,856	~200 min	The middle of the pack
CozyBecca, Quincy LK, DreamSaveArcade, byOBEE	—	4	~300	560	~90 min	The failures — see the honest section below

Channels using the “Fall asleep while I…” format. Subscriber counts pulled live; “n” = videos of this format found in the search sweep.

The honest distribution — because the table above flatters the format

240,893

median views across all 75 format videos

71%

cleared 100,000 views

11%

got under 10,000 views

80

views on the worst one found

The bottom decile sits at **7,081 views**; the top at **714,335**. So the format is not a lottery ticket — but the tail is real, and the channels sitting at 80–560 views are proof that posting the right title over the wrong execution gets you nothing.

The wider Minecraft-plus-sleep overlap is already enormous

Before worrying about whether Minecraft is the right background: it is comfortably the most proven one. These are all real, pulled numbers from the sweep.

CHANNEL	PEAK VIDEO	WHAT IT IS
aCookieGod 8.09M SUBS	7,704,825	"1 hour of Minecraft facts to help you sleep" — solo voice
bbswitzer	5,405,807	Relaxing Minecraft parkour — no talking at all
Drift Away Ambience	17,234,888	Minecraft music + rain — no talking , an entire channel of them
NoobAlike	22,186,377	Minecraft music box, 10 hours — no talking
Ambient Crafts	18,530,769	"all of a sudden, everything becomes alright..." — no talking
MadMorph	3,398,548	"Fall asleep while I play Minecraft" — solo voice
babyjamie1 307K SUBS	2,239,096	Reads Reddit stories over Minecraft parkour — solo voice
Chilled Fox	3,600,247	"it's 2014 and you fell asleep playing minecraft over christmas break" — nostalgia framing, no talking
Eider's Movies 20.1K SUBS	607,561	"Fall Asleep While I Test Every Minecraft Myth" — solo voice

The Minecraft × sleep overlap. Note that the two biggest have no talking at all — and that is the gap.

Read the right-hand column. The largest Minecraft sleep videos on YouTube — tens of millions of views — have *no voice on them at all*. The talking ones cap out around 3–8 million. That tells you two things: the background works and the audience is vast, and the talking layer is the thin, contested, high-value part. Every single voiced one is solo.

THE GENUINELY USEFUL COMPARISON

sleepyslorgs has 154,000 subscribers and a median of 341,108 views — 2.2 views per subscriber. MadMorph has 851,000 subscribers and a sleep-framed median of 235,000 — **0.28 per subscriber**. The smaller, funnier, edgier channel is getting *eight times more reach per subscriber*. This niche is driven by search and suggested, not by subscribers. A new channel is not as disadvantaged here as it would be in commentary or gaming.

04 · VIDEO LENGTH

Two hours, minimum. Non-negotiable.

This was measured two ways: across the whole spoken-sleep corpus, and inside MadMorph’s own catalogue (which removes channel-size bias entirely). Both point the same way.

Across the whole niche (557 spoken videos)

LENGTH	N	MEDIAN	P90
3–10 min	14	485,946	5,401,733
10–30 min	68	46,250	4,079,224
30–60 min	93	242,263	2,239,096
1–2 h	108	134,729	2,122,723
2–3 h	111	238,862	1,256,849
3–5 h	95	418,458	4,271,681
5–8 h	29	79,155	1,191,232
8 h+	39	95,012	930,063

Inside one channel (MadMorph, bias removed)

LENGTH	N	MEDIAN	P90
1–2 h	15	235,000	669,000
2–3 h	29	310,000	1,300,000
3–5 h	9	216,000	968,000

His own uploads cluster at **143 minutes median**, and 2–3 hours is his best bucket on both median and p90. He has effectively already run this experiment for you.

Across the 75 exact-format videos, the shortest is **57 minutes**, the median is **135 minutes**, the longest **346 minutes**. **Nothing under an hour appears in this format at all**. The dead zone is **20–40 minutes** — median 65,766 views across 87 videos, the worst bucket in the entire dataset.

WHY NOT 8 HOURS, WHEN 8H+ HAS THE HIGHEST MEDIAN OF ALL?

A wider sweep of 1,065 genre videos found the 8h+ bucket really does have the top median (**828,441**). But it is owned almost entirely by five legacy ambient channels — Relaxing White Noise, Calm, Soothing Relaxation, Yellow Brick Cinema — with a decade of search authority on “10 hours of rain” queries. **Not one spoken-word channel in the entire corpus reaches that bucket.** Meanwhile every talking channel measured — Sleepy History, Jason Stephenson, Kritikal Chronicles, MadMorph — locks onto 2–3 hours and stays there across its whole upload history regardless of era. That convergence is your answer. Competing at 8 hours means a format war against SEO moats you cannot out-rank; 2–3 hours is where voices actually win.

One more useful null result: across four fully-dumped channels, the correlation between a video’s length and its views *within* a channel is effectively zero (Pearson r between -0.14 and $+0.18$). Once you are in the right band, **going longer is not a lever**. Stop optimising length after two hours and put the effort into the hook instead.

THE NUMBER TO BUILD AROUND

Target 2 hours to 2 hours 30 minutes. That is one recording session, no editing beyond topping and tailing, and it sits precisely on the best-performing bucket in both datasets. Do not pad to 8 hours — it does not pay, and it hurts the ratio of talk to dead air.

05 · THE TWO-PERSON PROBLEM

Your biggest risk, and the fix

This is the part to read twice, because it is the one thing about your specific plan that the data pushes back on.

FINDING

Across roughly 225 results from nine targeted searches for two-person sleep content, **not one genuine, purpose-built, from-scratch two-friend sleep channel was found**. Every multi-person result at scale is *repurposed famous audio* — Karl Pilkington and Ricky Gervais re-cut as sleep content, *Would I Lie To You?* compilations, a Joe Pera loop. Those work because the voices are already familiar, which is exactly the thing a new channel cannot borrow. All seven of the biggest “talking over Minecraft footage” channels are **solo**.

Why it is empty — and it is not just that nobody tried

The mechanism that makes background audio work for sleep is a **steady, low-variance noise floor**. Sleep researchers and the creators who have optimised for it converge on the same point: the audio’s job is to occupy a racing mind, not to entertain it. The named failure mode in listener complaints is **sudden loudness** — a laugh spike, an interruption, a shout. Two friends bantering is structurally more prone to exactly that than one person narrating.

BUT THE COUNTER-EVIDENCE IS REAL, AND IT IS IN YOUR FAVOUR

- **MadMorph × Down To Sleep** — a two-person collaboration inside this exact format — returned a median of **407,306 views** over two videos, *higher* than MadMorph’s solo median. Two voices are not disqualifying.
- **sleepyslorgs** proves the *funny* half: “Fall Asleep While I Sell More Drugs” (447,467), “...Rob Rich People” (556,189), “...Operate Heavy Artillery” (598,004). Median 341,108 on 154k subs. Comedy sells in this niche.
- Comedic personal-story content is enormous adjacent to it: Tyler Vitelli’s “Embarrassing School Moments We All Had” has **5.4M views**, and his “1 hour of Tyler’s best stories to eat & sleep to” has **3.35M**. The Kalogeras Sisters’ two-person embarrassing-story video has **3.8M**.

THE WARNING SHOT: A FAMOUS SLEEP PODCAST GETS 582 VIEWS A VIDEO ON YOUTUBE

Sleep With Me is the best-known sleep podcast there is — deliberately monotone, built to be boring on purpose. On YouTube it has **40,500 subscribers and a median of 582 views across 200 videos**, with a best of 1,500. That is not a failure of the content; it is proof that **uploading a podcast to YouTube is not the same product as making a YouTube sleep video**. The channels winning here are built around *watchable calm footage* with a voice on top. The gameplay is not decoration — it is the reason the video works on this platform. Do not think of this as “our podcast, with Minecraft behind it.”

THE SINGLE PRODUCTION DECISION THAT RESOLVES THIS

The gap in the market is not “two friends talking” — that is a podcast. It is **two friends talking with the dynamics of a sleep aid**. Concretely, and this is the whole technical brief:

- **Hard-limit and compress the mix so laughs cannot spike.** Target roughly –16 LUFS integrated with a true peak ceiling around –1.5 dBTP and a tight loudness range. A laugh should be *audible*, never *louder*.
- **Never both raise your voice at once.** No shouting, no “NO WAY”, no talking over each other.
- **Game audio very low or off.** No sudden creeper, no damage sounds, no death screens.
- Record on **separate tracks** so you can level each other independently afterwards.

Get that right and you are the first proper entrant in a format the data says is empty. Get it wrong and you are a podcast with a misleading title, which is the 80-views outcome.

06 · CONTENT & STRUCTURE

What they actually say, and in what order

Real auto-captions were pulled from seven top videos in the genre and the opening 60–90 seconds read line by line. The conventions are unusually consistent.

Convention 1 — get to content in one sentence

There is **no “hey guys, welcome back” anywhere in the sample**. Six of the seven skip greeting entirely and open cold on the first fact or the first line of the story.

“this is your warning to never be friends with a bilingual person because I have a friend that speaks English and Spanish...”

Tyler Vitelli — comedic storytime, 3.35M views. First words of the video.

“welcome to another riveting story time from my compendium of social ineptitude — today’s story takes place during high school when I thought break dancing was the dopest...”

Critikal Chronicles — 3.4M views.

Convention 2 — the sleep promise lives in the title, not the script

Only one of the seven said anything resembling a sleep ritual out loud. That one is the market leader, and it is worth copying:

“in this video I’m going to play Minecraft and talk to you gently while you fall asleep... this is episode 5 of my fall asleep with series... let’s tuck you in — take a nice deep breath for me — and let’s get down to sleep with Minecraft.”

MadMorph — 3.4M views. The full opening: format explainer, series number, ritual cue, ~20 seconds.

Convention 3 — the gameplay gets referenced, the wallpaper does not

This splits cleanly. Videos with *live gameplay* behind them talk to it constantly — it is what stops the talk track feeling like a podcast:

“back up a tree again as always... I’ve turned the render distance up — what is that, is that a horse? I see a horse in the distance, let’s swim over and say hello.”

MadMorph, mid-video.

Videos with static images or stock footage never mention the visuals at all. Since you are playing Minecraft live, you are in the first camp — **react to the game between story beats**. It is free filler, it is what makes the format not-a-podcast, and it gives you somewhere to go when a story runs out.

Convention 4 — nothing must depend on having heard the last ten minutes

Every performing format here is structurally dip-in-and-out-of: facts in a list, Reddit threads back to back, unrelated anecdotes stacked. **No cliffhangers, no running plot, no “remember when I said...”**. The

viewer is going to lose consciousness mid-sentence and must lose nothing by it. Your “worst rizz attempts” idea is perfectly shaped for this — it is a stack of independent anecdotes. Your “graduation went wrong” idea is a single narrative, which is weaker for the format unless you pad it out with surrounding school stories.

Convention 5 — “No Ads” is a selling point

Multiple high performers put **(No Ads)** or **No Adverts** directly in the title. Creators only advertise that when the opposite is a known complaint — being woken up by a mid-roll. Keep this in your back pocket: it is a real differentiator once you are monetised and can choose.

07 · TITLES

Your two ideas, graded — and 15 to start with

“Fall asleep to how my high school graduation went wrong”

REWORK IT

Right instinct, wrong shape. Problems: it is a *single* story, so it cannot sustain two hours; “went wrong” is vague, and the format rewards a specific promise. Also the winning verb pattern is “**while I / while we**”, not “to how”.

Better: “*Fall asleep while we tell you every school story we’ve never told anyone*” — the graduation disaster becomes the opening anecdote and the thumbnail hook, not the whole video.

“Fall asleep to our worst rizz attempts”

STRONG — LEAD WITH THIS

This is the better of the two and it should be video one. It is a *stack* of independent anecdotes (perfect for the format), it is inherently two-person, it is funny in the low-stakes embarrassing register that demonstrably works, and “rizz” carries its own search demand.

Tightened: “*Fall asleep while we tell you our worst rizz attempts (2 hours)*”

The title formula, from the data

Every high performer in the exact-format set follows one pattern: “**Fall Asleep While I/We [verb + specific thing]**”, optionally with a length or parenthetical. Long titles are fine — the winners run 40–70 characters. The verb is doing the work: “Sell More Drugs”, “Rob Rich People”, “Operate Heavy Artillery”, “Build a Nuclear Bomb in My Garden”. Specific and slightly absurd beats calm and generic.

- 1 Fall asleep while we tell you our worst rizz attempts
- 2 Fall asleep while we play Minecraft and tell you our most embarrassing stories
- 3 Fall asleep while we build a house and ruin each other’s reputations
- 4 Fall asleep while we tell you every school story we’ve never told anyone
- 5 Fall asleep while we argue about the dumbest things (2 hours)
- 6 Fall asleep while we tell you how we got banned from everywhere

- 7 Fall asleep while we play Minecraft and rank our worst dates
- 8 Fall asleep while we tell you the stories our parents can never hear
- 9 Fall asleep while we build a village and overshare for 2 hours
- 10 Fall asleep while we tell you what actually happened at prom
- 11 Fall asleep while we play Minecraft and confess everything (No Ads)
- 12 Fall asleep while we tell you our worst texts ever sent
- 13 Fall asleep while we survive a Minecraft world and our teenage years
- 14 Fall asleep while we tell you every time we embarrassed ourselves in public
- 15 Fall asleep while we play Minecraft and answer questions we shouldn't

Which title devices actually correlate with views

801 genre-relevant videos were split into the top and bottom 150 by views and every common title device measured. **Title length is not the lever** (67.8 vs 70.6 characters — a wash). The lift column below is median views *with* the device divided by median views *without*.

DEVICE	LIFT	VERDICT
Brackets / parentheses — e.g. <i>(Minecraft Parkour)</i>	1.47×	n=155, broad-based. The one reliable positive. Use it.
"Black Screen"	4.22×	n=12, concentrated in a few white-noise giants. Not applicable to you.
"Sleep Story / Stories"	0.87×	Neutral
Second-person "you"	0.84×	Neutral
Explicit duration ("3 Hours")	0.66×	Put it in the thumbnail instead
"No Ads"	0.63×	Save it for later
ALL CAPS word	0.59×	Avoid
Any number	0.53×	Avoid
Emoji	0.41×	Avoid
"ASMR"	0.35×	Avoid — wrong audience for you

Title device lift across 801 genre videos. Read the caveat underneath before acting on it.

DO NOT OVER-READ THAT TABLE

Most of those clichés correlating with *lower* views is a channel-size confound, not causation. The giants (Calm, Jason Stephenson, Moshi) write clean editorial titles because they do not need SEO stuffing; small channels stack every cliché to compensate and sit in the bottom tier. The honest takeaway is not “never say ASMR” — it is **one clear hook beats device-stacking**. Keep one genre marker and one bracket tag. Do not pile five more on top.

TWO TITLE RULES THAT COME STRAIGHT OUT OF THE FAILURE CASES

1. Never write a title that sounds energetic. Caps, exclamation marks and “INSANE” break the promise before the click. **2. Put the runtime in the thumbnail, not the title.** Someone choosing a video at midnight is choosing a *duration* — but the data says the number belongs on the image, not in the text.

07B · THUMBNAILS

The visual system, measured

The top 15 thumbnails in the niche were downloaded and looked at directly. The convention is far more consistent than in most niches — and it is the *opposite* of standard YouTube advice.

86%

dark / low-key palette

71%

specifically blue, teal or navy

7%

contain a real human face

36%

use moon / stars / night sky

Only **one of fifteen** had a real face on it. Counting cartoon and animal faces, still only three. **71% carry text, but never more than two to four words** — bold sans-serif, white on dark, never a sentence. The dominant formula is: **no face, dark blue palette, minimal bold text, one night motif**. A calm mood shot, not a shocked-face thumbnail.

YOUR THUMBNAIL SPEC

- **Base:** a still from your own Minecraft footage, colour-graded dark — desaturate and push towards navy/near-black. Night scenes, lanterns, rain, a lit window.
- **No face close-ups.** If you want to signal “two people”, use two silhouettes or two Minecraft characters sitting down — not smiling photos of you both.
- **Text:** two short lines max. The hook word and the twist word. Large bold sans-serif, white, thin dark outline. Put the runtime here as a small tag.
- **One accent colour only**, and one small moon-or-stars cue. That is the entire night signal.
- **No red arrows, no circles, no oversaturation.** In this niche, restraint *is* the trust signal — a loud thumbnail reads as “this will keep me awake”.

The monetisation reality

Verified against YouTube’s own policy documentation. The good news is that the format is safe; the caution is that the money per view is not the attraction — the *watch hours* are.

POLICY: YOU ARE CLEAR VERIFIED

On **15 July 2025** YouTube renamed its “repetitious content” rule to “**inauthentic content**”. It targets templated, AI-slideshow, near-zero-effort mass production. Original commentary over gameplay is explicitly fine under the separate, unchanged *reused content* policy, which permits monetisation where there is “significant original commentary, editing, or educational/entertainment value”. **Two friends telling their own stories over their own Minecraft footage is about as original as it gets.** No YouTube policy document names sleep content at all — it is judged per video, not by genre.

MINECRAFT AUDIO: OFFICIALLY FINE, PRACTICALLY IMPERFECT

Mojang’s usage guidelines permit monetised use of official Minecraft music in game-related content. But real Content ID false claims have hit named creators on C418 tracks. Over a 2-hour video that is a lot of exposure. **Turn the in-game music off and use royalty-free ambience** — you lose nothing and remove the risk entirely.

TIME-SENSITIVE — THE BAR IS ABOUT TO DOUBLE ACT BEFORE FEB 2027

The YouTube Partner Programme currently needs **1,000 subscribers plus 4,000 watch hours in 12 months**, or **10 million Shorts views in 90 days** (note: 10 million, not the 3 million figure that circulates). **From 1 February 2027 those thresholds double to 8,000 watch hours and 20 million Shorts views.** If you start now and hit 4,000 hours before then you are grandfathered in under the easier bar; if you drift, you need twice as much. This is the single strongest argument for starting immediately rather than in the new year.

The watch-hours arithmetic — this is the actual argument for long videos

Long sleep videos are extraordinarily efficient at clearing the watch-hour bar, because the viewer is asleep and the tab keeps running.

VIDEO LENGTH	20% RETENTION	35% RETENTION	50% RETENTION
10 minutes	120,000 views	68,571	48,000
1 hour	20,000 views	11,429	8,000
2 hours	10,000 views	5,714	4,000

VIDEO LENGTH	20% RETENTION	35% RETENTION	50% RETENTION
3 hours	6,667 views	3,810	2,667

Views needed to reach 4,000 watch hours, by video length and average view duration. Arithmetic, not a claim about what retention you will get.

Read the middle column. At a 2-hour runtime and 35% average view duration, you need roughly **5,700 views total** — not per video, in a year — to clear the watch-hour half of monetisation. Six uploads averaging a thousand views each would do it. This is the single biggest structural advantage of the format, and it is why the length recommendation in §04 is not negotiable.

UNVERIFIED — TREAT AS DIRECTIONAL ONLY

Every RPM/CPM figure found for sleep and ASMR content (the commonly cited \$3–\$11 range) came from content-marketing blogs with no disclosed methodology. No audited or creator-reported figures could be confirmed. Assume sleep RPM is **below** gaming and commentary — the audience is asleep, which is bad for advertisers — and treat ad revenue as a bonus rather than the plan. A 2025 home-feed redesign is reported to have cut long-form recommendation slots in favour of Shorts; that comes from a single trade-press source and could not be cross-verified, but it does point the same way as the Shorts strategy below.

YOUTUBE'S SLEEP TIMER WORKS AGAINST YOU SLIGHTLY VERIFIED

The Sleep Timer is real and now available to everyone, not just Premium. It auto-pauses playback — which plausibly cuts off later mid-roll opportunities in exactly the long videos this genre relies on. Not a blocker, but another reason not to model this as an ad-revenue business early on.

09 · SHORTS

What to clip, and why Shorts matter here

Shorts are not where this niche lives — long-form is. But they are the cheapest discovery you have, and your format generates them for free.

THE STRUCTURAL INSIGHT

Nobody falls asleep to a Short. So do not make sleep Shorts — **make funny Shorts that advertise a sleep video**. Your two-hour recording contains 15–20 clippable punchlines. The Short sells the joke; the pinned comment and the end screen sell the two-hour version. You are using the comedy lane for discovery and the sleep lane for retention, which is exactly the arbitrage the 5.6× number in §02 describes.

Five formats to cut from every recording

1. **The single worst attempt.** 30–45 s, one complete anecdote with a punchline. Text hook on frame one: “the worst thing I have ever said to a girl”. Minecraft footage behind it.
2. **The reaction clip.** Your friend’s genuine response to your story. Two-person content outperforms solo in Shorts even though it underperforms in sleep long-form — different rules, use both.
3. **The “we shouldn’t have said that” clip.** Cut on the moment one of you regrets speaking. High rewatch.
4. **The gameplay-fail sync.** A punchline that lands exactly as something goes wrong in Minecraft. Free comic timing — watch for these while recording and note the timestamp.
5. **The direct trailer.** 20 s, three rapid story titles, ending on “...all two hours are on the channel.” Post this one last, once the long video is live.

THE ONE THING TO GET RIGHT MECHANICALLY

Use YouTube’s “**Related video**” link on every Short so it points at the long-form upload — it is the only native path YouTube documents, it is explicitly scoped to videos *on your own channel*, and most people never set it. Back it up with a pinned comment and a spoken call-out. **Do not split Shorts onto a second channel** — you would forfeit that link for a “cleaner algorithm signal” that nothing in the research substantiates.

HONEST LIMITS ON THE SHORTS DATA WEAKEST SECTION

Shorts are the least well-evidenced part of this report and it would be dishonest to dress it up. Of 752 shorts-targeted results, only 102 were genuinely short-form with view counts, the overall median was **50 views**, and the p90 was **2.3 million** — an extreme power law where almost everything dies. Worse, the specific combination you are planning (storytime narration over Minecraft, cut to a Short) returned only 12 matching titles and they were nearly all dead, median **6 views**. That is not evidence it fails — keyword search is a bad instrument for finding that sub-format — but it is not evidence it works either. Where the buckets had real sample size, **90–180 second Shorts beat 60–90 second ones** on both median and p90, so lean long within Shorts. Treat Shorts as cheap optionality, not as the growth plan.

10 · THE PLAN

First 90 days

Before you record	• Set up separate audio tracks for each of you. This is the one thing that cannot be fixed later. • Turn in-game music off. Lower game SFX until they sit clearly under your voices. • Pick a calm Minecraft activity that lasts hours and never spikes: building, terraforming, a peaceful-mode world. Not PvP, not combat, not anything with a death sound. • Write a list of 25–30 story prompts. You will burn through more than you think in two hours.
Weeks 1–4 Prove the format	1 long video per week. 2–2.5 hours each. 3–4 Shorts per week cut from it. • Week 1: <i>Fall asleep while we tell you our worst rizz attempts</i> • Week 2: <i>Fall asleep while we tell you every school story we've never told anyone</i> (graduation story opens it) • Week 3: <i>Fall asleep while we play Minecraft and rank our worst dates</i> • Week 4: <i>Fall asleep while we build a house and confess everything</i> Do not judge anything yet. Sleep content is search-driven and back-loads views over months.
Weeks 5–8 Find the hook	Same cadence. Now look at which of the four titles pulled best and make two more of that one. Watch the retention graph for the first 60 seconds specifically — that is where sleep videos are won or lost. Add a chapter list. Start putting the runtime in the thumbnail.
Weeks 9–12 Compound	Build a playlist that autoplays through the night — this is the highest-leverage thing in the niche and almost nobody does it properly. Aim for 12–14 long videos live by day 90. Around here the watch-hour threshold should fall out naturally from the arithmetic in §08.

The five ways this fails

1. **Volume spikes.** One genuine laugh at full level wakes the viewer and they never come back. This is the number-one risk and it is entirely a mixing problem.
2. **Too short.** Anything under an hour does not exist in this format. A 40-minute upload is a podcast with the wrong title.
3. **Quitting at week 6.** Sleep content accrues views over months through search, not in the first 48 hours. Judging it on day-one performance is the standard way people abandon a working channel.

4. **Being interesting.** Genuinely — cliffhangers and running plots are a bug here. Nothing may depend on staying awake.
5. **Copying MadMorph's tone instead of his framing.** His gentle solo register is his moat. Yours is being two friends who are funny at low volume. Take the title structure and the runtime; do not take the whisper.

BOTTOM LINE

The concept is validated by a controlled, within-channel **5.6×** and a **240,893-view median** across the format. A 20,100-sub channel pulled 607,561 views on one upload. The niche has fewer than ten serious competitors and **no established two-person entrant at all**. Your edge is being first into the duo lane; your risk is that the duo lane is empty because banter is loud. Solve that in the mix and the rest is upload cadence.

Sources & confidence. All view counts, durations and subscriber counts were pulled live from YouTube on 4 September 2026 via 61 search queries and 14 full channel dumps (2,300+ unique videos). Policy claims are sourced from YouTube's own support documentation and Mojang's usage guidelines. Items marked **UNVERIFIED** — all RPM/CPM figures, the reported 2025 home-feed change, and comment-section sentiment — could not be confirmed against a primary source and are flagged rather than presented as fact. Search-derived samples over-represent successful videos; the within-channel comparisons in §02 and §04 are included specifically to control for that.